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Storytelling

I grew up in an ancient story: the story of a people—my people. The story is told every year at the Passover seder. I recently found a photo of our Passover seder in Germany in 1948. My father, the chaplain, is leading the seder in uniform at a mic; my mother, seated to his left, is looking glowingly at me: as the youngest person there (all of five), I had just finished asking the Four Questions about why this particular night is different from all other nights and to which the rest of the seder is a response. The prayer book for the seder is called, quite simply, the Haggadah, “the story.”

When I began to work in Mississippi, I found myself within the telling of yet another chapter of the same story: the arduous journey from slavery to freedom. As Dr. King declared the night before his assassination:

I would watch God’s children in their magnificent trek from the dark dungeons of Egypt through, or rather across, the Red Sea, through the wilderness on toward the promised land. . . . I just want to do God’s will. And He’s allowed me to go up to the mountain. And I’ve looked over. And I’ve seen the promised land. I may not get there with you. But I want you to know tonight, that we, as a people, will get to the promised land.¹

Like the story in which I grew up, this story wasn’t just told. It was celebrated—in church, in mass meetings, in song. Although the Christian narrative of the Black church was new to me, the religious sensibility with which I grew up helped me get it better than some of my secular companions. To “testify” in church was to tell a story linking one’s personal redemption with that of one’s church and one’s faith. In movement mass meetings, testimony linked one’s personal freedom story to that of the community and the movement.

The farmworker movement told its story as well, a story deeply rooted in Mexican culture, in the Mexican Catholic tradition, in its revolutionary tradition, and in the traditions of everyday life. Values central to Catholic social teaching, renewed by Vatican II, interwove with strands of the civil rights movement and American labor history. We celebrated this story in a

Eucharistic mass, on picket lines that became *vigilias*, on marches that became *peregrinaciones*, and in mass meetings rich in song, theater, and solidarity. By the time I left the farmworkers, I had learned that to try organizing without a story is to try organizing without a heart—the emotional resources we need not only to launch a struggle but also to sustain it, and in the end, to win.

By the time I began teaching here in 1994, I had learned that without a story of hope, not much would happen. Grievances may abound, but few would act without a spark of hope—real hope. In 1997, when I joined a doctoral seminar on the neurophysiology of myth, I began to understand the link between how stories work and how our brains work.² I explored this connection further with my colleague Bernie Steinberg, director of Harvard Hillel. Guided by his teaching I discovered whole new depths of meaning in the familiar Bible stories with which I grew up, if we read them as the stories they are, not as theology. When I finished my dissertation—having identified the critical role of narrative motivation in strategy—I committed to deeper study of how narrative works, its role in organizing, and how to teach it. In 2005, while on leave after the death of my wife, Susan, and doing narrative work of my own, Adam Reich and I came up with a way to do it. I called it “public narrative” and tried it out in a course at Harvard Kennedy School, a project with Sierra Club chapters, and at Camp Obama sessions in 2007/8. It turned out that it worked—not because it came from the academy but because everyone tells stories.

What Is Public Narrative?

In the first seven minutes of his keynote address to the 2004 Democratic Convention, Barack Obama begins by sharing his story: the choices that shaped his life and the values driving those choices. He then reminds us of our own shared stories: the values that unite us, the choices we have made, our sources of hope. He then confronts us with challenges to those values, enlivens our sources of hope, and inspires us with hope: he describes for us the America that could be, but only if we step up, accept responsibility, and make it happen: a story of now. He wasn’t calling us to choose what *he* wanted. He was calling us to find the courage to choose what *we* wanted. He shared a “story of self,” a “story of us,” and a “story of now.” Although he didn’t

call it that, this was his public narrative, a talk with which he introduced himself to America.

Public narrative wasn't invented at Harvard. In fact, it's more of a discovery than an invention. An early instance of which I'm aware is recounted in Exodus 8. Moses—the Jew who is an Egyptian, of the oppressed but raised in the house of the oppressor—at once was confronted with this identity conflict. He sees a slave being abused by a taskmaster and kills the taskmaster, an action that earns him not the support of the captive Israelites but rather their fearful condemnation of him for “rocking the boat.” So, he flees into the desert, which is where, in the Bible, you go to figure things out. He finds a spouse, a family, and a job as a shepherd. One day he's walking along with his sheep and sees a glow off to the side of the road; he's a curious fellow, so he steps off the road only to find a bush that is burning but not being consumed. At that point he hears the voice, the timbre of which is uncertain, “Moses, you are called to free your people.”

For those familiar with the text, how does Moses respond? “Wait a second! Why me? You've got the wrong guy! I can't even give a speech. I've got an impediment,” then, “And who exactly are you and these people of yours who won't accept me?” And then, “Couldn't this wait?” To which God responds with the promise of help from Moses's brother Aaron, as well as a staff that can turn into a snake to spook Pharaoh's magicians.

Why me? Why us? Why now? These are ancient questions. And I've yet to find a culture in which people don't ask themselves these questions. They give different answers, to be sure, but the questions are the same.

Public narrative, then, is a way we can harness the power of narrative to the work of leadership: accepting responsibility for enabling others to achieve shared purpose under conditions of uncertainty. I can tell a story of self to enable others to “get” me by sharing my moments of hurt (why I care) and moments of hope (why I can) and the values motivating how I chose to respond to them. I can tell a story of us to enable others to “get” each other by recalling shared moments of hurt and of hope and how we responded to them, expressing values we share. We can tell a story of now to access sources of courage to transform a current moment of disruption from a threat from which I flee fearfully into a challenge with which I can engage hopefully: from thoughtless reaction into mindful response—the exercise of agency.

In this way we can use narrative to construct an empathetic bridge with others to enable them to respond mindfully to the disruptive impact of

loss, difference, domination, and change. By weaving articulation of these moments into a coherent story, we can share a motivational experience of our individual and collective values. Through the coherent articulation of narrative moments, we can mutually construct our individual and collective identities.

The dynamics of narrative, emotion, and values grow out of the work of Jerome Bruner, the twentieth-century cultural psychologist who taught for many years at the Harvard Graduate School of Education. Bruner argued that we interpret the world in distinct paradigmatic and narrative modes.³ The paradigmatic mode relies primarily on a cognitive mapping of the world, within which we identify patterns, discern connections, hypothesize empirical claims and test them, and construct explanatory frames based on what we've come to believe about what *is* in the world. The narrative mode relies primarily on an affective mapping of the world, through which we valorize experiences, objects, symbols, and people as fearful or safe, hopeful or depressing, soothing or unsettling. We construct narratives based on what we have come to believe *is good* in the world.⁴

We use the paradigmatic mode to answer the question of how: How can we efficiently and effectively achieve our goals? We use the narrative mode to answer the question of why: Why are these our goals, why do we care, why can we be hopeful, why must we choose, why must we act?

The Power of Stories

Where did you hear your first stories? Who told them to you? Most of us hear them from our parents, grandparents, aunts, uncles, and other caregivers who told them to us in our early years, even as we began learning how to tell our own stories. Those stories shape a child's formation of their understanding of the world, themselves, and the relationship between the two. Why so many stories? To instruct? What is it that stories do that a list of dos and don'ts cannot?

All stories have a plot, a character, and a moral. Stories have a *plot*: they begin with a disruption, narrate a response, and yield an outcome. We experience the emotional content of these moment by identifying with the *character*, the protagonist. This experience then teaches an experiential *moral* that teaches not only the head but, more importantly, the heart, in this way

our experience of the story can become part of our own experience, an experience we can draw on when we face challenges of our own.

Because our stories, like all stories, begin in the beginning, by sharing our “origin stories” we can most effectively, and accessibly, communicate our values sources: moments early in life when we learned to care—often moments of hurt—and moments in which we experienced our worth, our value—often moments of hope. Because everyone tells stories, and because our beginnings are often fraught with similar challenges, sharing our origin stories can communicate shared values surprisingly well across the cultural, racial, class, and gender boundaries that separate us.

And because a well-told story moment can bring a felt experience of the past into the present, we become emotionally present as well, thus communicating the emotional meaning of this unique moment. The specificity of a particular moment can thus become, like a poem, a portal to the transcendent. In this chapter I show how we can link the power of story to the work of leadership as *public narrative*: a story of self, a story of us, and a story of now.

Public narrative is a *framework* not a *formula*, so the order of the stories (self, us, now) can be varied and played with, as long as they make sense and flow together in a clear, cohesive way. In a linked narrative, the three elements (self, us, now) are told through story moments with all the elements of the craft present: challenge, choice, outcome, and hope. You are *telling* the stories, not telling *about* the stories.

We all learn to tell stories, implicitly if not explicitly.⁵ So by making the implicit explicit, we can learn to practice storytelling as a craft with intentionality, skill, and sustained learning. We will look first at the emotional dimension of storytelling; then, at the structural dimension; and then, how they come together in the leadership practice of public narrative.

Emotion, Values, and Leadership

When we tell stories, we speak in the language of emotion. Speaking the language of emotion is not irrational, reactive, or thoughtless. Music speaks the language of emotion, as do worship, poetry, theater, and sports. Emotions inform us of what we value in ourselves, in others, and in the world. The

emotional information we experience as feelings is partly physiological, as when our respiration or body temperature changes; partly behavioral, as when we are moved to advance or to flee, to stand up or to sit down; and partly cognitive, as we describe what we feel as fear, love, desire, or joy.

Emotions provide us with vital information about how to live our lives. This emotional information is not better than analytic reasoning but more of a precondition for it.⁶ Decisions are ultimately based on value judgments, and value judgments require emotional information. In fact, moral philosopher Martha Nussbaum cites research on people afflicted with lesions on the amygdala, an element of the brain central to emotional experience. When called upon to solve problems, they can reason multiple options but cannot decide on which to act. But relying on emotional information is not consigning ourselves to the realm of the irrational. On the contrary, as Blaise Pascal observed, “The heart has its reasons, which reason does not know.”⁷ Some of our emotions enable intentional, mindful, and agentic action, while other emotions inhibit it.

When it comes to public leadership, the emotional challenge is how to enable others to experience a disruption as real enough to motivate action (Figure 3.1). At the same time, it is to enable others to encounter disruption courageously enough to choose a mindful response rather than a fearful reaction in lieu of making a choice.

Most of the time, we rely on habit, often reinforced by feelings of inertia and apathy. This can be efficient. I don’t have to relearn how to drive my car each time I want to go somewhere. But when something unexpected happens, like a truck suddenly pulling out in front of me, my surveillance system compares what I’m expecting with what is actually happening and signals me with anxiety. Without this emotional cue, political psychologist George Marcus argues, we may remain on autopilot.⁸ This anxiety is beneficial because it confronts us with the reality that we are not in a business-as-usual moment but are in one that may require a strategic or agentic response. This is constructive because humans are very good at screening out data that conflict with our cognitive frames or assumptions—a consistency bias—and because a comforting sense of inertia (it’s always worked out this way) or resigned apathy (nothing we do works anyway) reinforces an inaction bias. An emotional shock or disruption can penetrate habit enough to enable recognition of a novel disruption that demands a strategic response. Anxiety tells us, “Hey! Pay attention!”

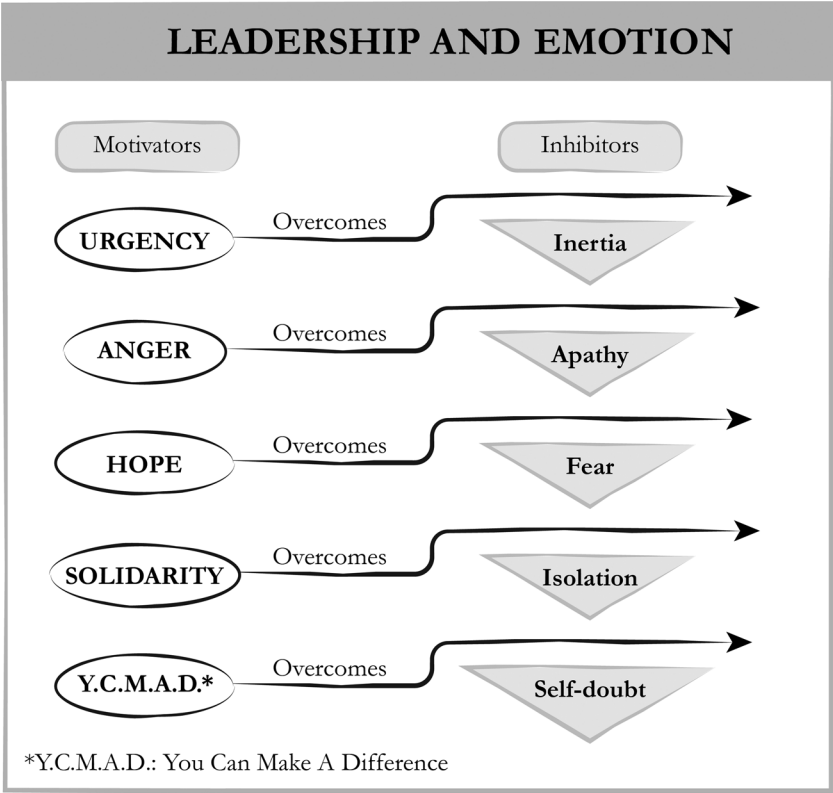


Figure 3.1 Leadership and Emotion. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Urgency and Anger

Our leadership challenge may be to awaken people to an urgent need for intentional action in response to a disruption, not yet experienced as immediately proximate or threatening. It often involves challenging people with the contradictions in what we may assume to be the case and our own lived experience—a technique organizers describe as agitation.⁹ The climate change movement has long struggled with the fact that carbon parts per million only became urgent when floods and fires forcefully intruded on daily lives.

Urgency establishes priorities. I may need to decide on my future vocation, but I have an exam in the morning so, especially if unprepared, I must study tonight. I may need to study tonight but they’re coming to evict our

family first thing in the morning, so I'd better start packing. There are two kinds of urgency: *urgency of need* and *urgency of opportunity*. Urgency of need can be created by a condition so intolerable that it demands immediate action: a child is ripped from its parent's arms at a border crossing; a young Black man is murdered in public view by a police officer; a ban on Muslims entering the United States is announced; another mass shooting demands a protest. Urgency of opportunity is created by a deadline by which action must be taken if it is to have any effect at all: the vote on restricting reproductive choice is in just three days; if I don't find my rent money by next week, I'm out on the street.

Balancing the important and the urgent can be challenging. Those trying to mobilize a vitally important response to climate change must also make it urgent. The urgent can displace the important when a critical volunteer training that has been in the making for three months is suddenly cancelled in reaction to a small shift in the polling numbers. Two weeks before the election, the call goes out, "Where are our volunteers?"

Sometimes social movements can mobilize a caring public, as well as their own constituency, in response to the "moral urgency" of their cause. In 1960, for example, in Greensboro, North Carolina, Black students denied service at a segregated lunch counter polarized the moment by refusing to leave. They're being spit on, beaten, jailed. We can't wait any longer. We must act now. The Occupy Wall Street movement set up shop in New York's Zuccotti Park in 2011 and refused to leave; they too created a moment of "moral urgency" that moved much of the public to recognize, if not act on, the challenges of economic inequality. When the Dreamers risked deportation by "coming out" to claim their undocumented status in public, it also created "moral urgency" among their supporters. And the widespread protests in response to the televised police murder of George Floyd in Minneapolis in 2020 responded to the "moral urgency" created by what the nation had seen, had witnessed.¹⁰

Anger can also counter habitual apathy or inertia not as rage but as outrage: the experience of the dissonance between the world as it is and the world as it ought to be. As individuals we may become angry if someone or something robs us of our dignity or self-respect: the experience of moments of domination, discrimination, bullying, violation, or neglect, regardless of attempts to legitimate them. Communities may react with anger not only to the foregoing but also to violations of their "moral order," evident in the culture wars dominating US politics.¹¹ People rarely mobilize to protest inequality or even low wages as such, as inconvenient as these may be. They

do mobilize to protest “unjust” inequality or low wages, a kind of moral dissonance that crosses the line.¹² In other words, assaults on our values, our moral traditions, or our personal or community dignity can function as critical sources of the anger that can motivate action.

Fear and Hope and Choice

If anger or urgency can create critical experiences of disruptive anxiety, whether they spark courage or aggression depends on whether they partner with fear or with hope.¹³ Unfortunately, fear is often our default reaction to any disruption. We’re all well acquainted with fear, one of the first emotions we experience, provocative of all the crying for comfort. Fear is a hardwired reaction to perceived threat: flight, fight, or freeze. This was an adaptive response when the disruption may have taken the form of a saber-toothed tiger. But especially as we began to live in larger communities, reacting to any source of disruption with fear could be deeply destructive. And when combined with anger, it often leads to hateful aggression toward an identified source threat—the “dangerous other.” And if anchored in isolation and self-doubt, the more a yearning for safety abounds, at times accompanied by despair.

We began finding the emotional resources with which we could manage our fears—principal among them is hope. Hope, unlike optimism, sees clearly what can be a fearsome reality but responds to it in a spirit of “could be” or “possibility,” a space between certainty and fantasy.¹⁴ The twelfth-century philosopher Maimonides understood hope as belief in the plausibility of the possible as opposed to the necessity of the probable.¹⁵ We live in a world in which it is always probable Goliath will win, but sometimes David does. It was highly improbable we would elect a Black man president of the United States, but it happened.

When anger combines with hope, it can become a source of the courage we need to transform a threat from which we must flee into a challenge with which we can engage. In concert with the experience of self-worth (“you can make a difference”) and solidarity (love, empathy), hope can move us to act.

So where do we go to get hope? Many people draw hope from the stories expressive of their faith, cultural, and moral traditions, often accompanied by the experiences of transcendence or “awe.”¹⁶ The American civil rights movement, the Polish Solidarity movement, and Gandhi’s Swaraj movement

for Indian independence directly or indirectly drew strength from religious traditions. Indeed, much of the community organizing going on in the United States today is rooted in faith communities. Another source of hope is our own experiences of self-efficacy—a small success, an overcoming of the odds—and solidarity—a parent who believed in us, a friend who stood up for us, a person in whose life we made a difference. And we all know people who simply inspire hopefulness in others—a form of “charisma” rooted not in hero worship but in their enabling others to experience their own value, their belovedness, their possibilities. Cultivating a sense of possibility—not certainty—is to cultivate sources of hope.¹⁷

Feelings of isolation can both result from and contribute to fear. We counter isolation with experiences of belovedness or solidarity or community. Mass meetings during the civil rights movement were not only shows of strength or reports on progress but also celebrations of community, solidarity, and love. Singing was an embodiment of that love. Group activities like singing help individuals experience the values shared by the community.

Leaders counter self-doubt by enabling people to experience a sense of self-efficacy, that *you* can make a difference. Leaders can contribute to this sense of worth by enabling the experience of respect. Most of us experience disrespect, as well as respect, in very similar ways. The heart of the experience of respect is being seen, being heard, and being valued. Most of us get a pretty good sense of whether we’re being seen or just being looked at. We also know if we are being heard or being observed. And we know if we are being valued or being used. The starting point to building self-efficacy is being fully present to each other.

Exercising leadership, then, requires engaging in an emotional conversation that draws on positive emotions grounded in one set of experiences to counter negative emotions grounded in different experiences or circumstances—a dialogue of the heart. This kind of dialogue can restore the hope for change that had been abandoned in despair.

Craft, Values, and Leadership

The Story Moment

Stories teach through story moments. A story moment is a specific event in which we are confronted with an anxiety-creating disruption to which we

must react or respond. To the extent we experience it as a threat, we are likely to react fearfully, to retreat. To the extent we experience it as a challenge, we are likely to respond thoughtfully, to explore. The outcome teaches a moral not so much to the head as to the heart. This is so because we can identify empathetically with the person of the protagonist, feel the fear as if it were our own, feel the hope as if it were our own. And most importantly, we can feel the source of value on which the protagonist draws to respond with solidarity, dignity, faith, compassion, loyalty, and so on. The moral is not only a set of words but an emotional experience, an experience of the heart, an experience that can become our own.

A story moment encompasses a challenge, a choice, and an outcome (Figure 3.2). It is not simply the description of a scene, like that of a beautiful sunset. It is dynamic, an experience of change. For example, I was watching the beautiful sunset with my partner when it began to rain. As I turned to go, she reached out and took my arm. “It’s only rain,” she said. “We’ll be fine as long as we’re together.” Something happened. A challenge elicited a choice that yielded an outcome. And we are offered a moral: love can conquer adversity.

Story moments are nested. Story educator Robert McKee describes this moment as a “beat” (challenge, choice, outcome), each one of which is nested within a larger story moment, a scene; each scene is nested within a still larger story moment, an act; and each act is nested within a much larger story moment, a play.¹⁸

The story begins. A character is moving toward a desired goal. But then, suddenly, there is a disruption, a threat. Now what? All plans are off. All eyes are on the character who must figure out what to do, who must make a choice. Now we get interested. Do they react fearfully? Are they scared? Do they get a grip? Do they respond thoughtfully? They choose. It works! It doesn’t work. There’s an outcome.

The Character (Protagonist)

When we identify empathetically with a character, the protagonist of the story, we can experience the emotional content of their experience almost as if it were our own. We can experience the fear. We can experience the hope. We can experience the sources of that hope—often the hard-earned values of the character. We understand now that the mechanism of mirror

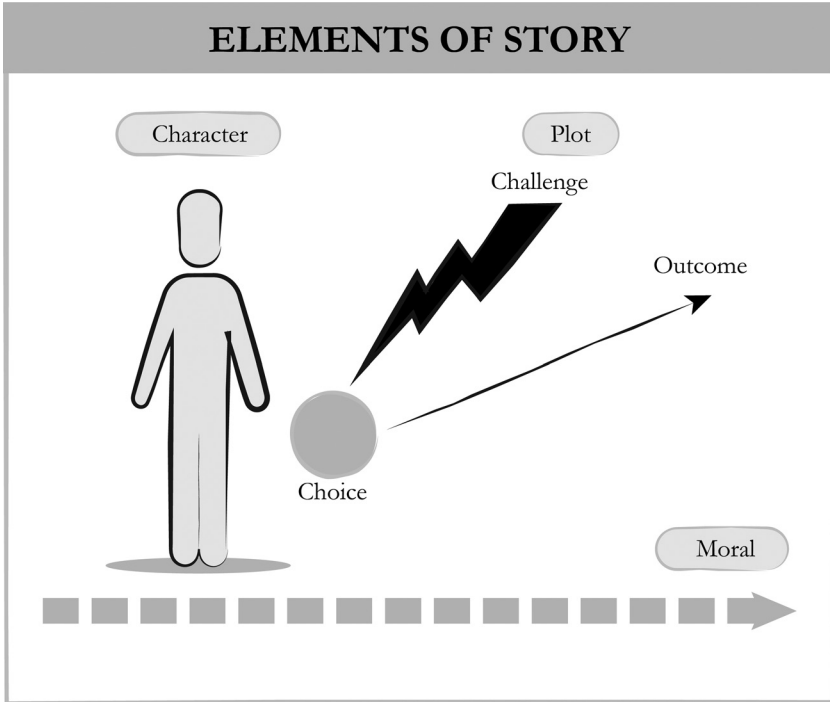


Figure 3.2 Elements of Story. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

neurons enables us to experience the actions of another we can observe almost as if they were our own, knowledge held by storytellers for literally thousands of years.¹⁹ What we hope to learn, then, is not so much the tactics of accomplishing the goal. This is emotional learning—where the character finds the hope, the courage, the persistence, and the creativity to persist. As Aristotle wrote of Greek tragedy, this is how the protagonist's experience can touch us and, perhaps, open our eyes.²⁰

Sometimes we identify with protagonists who are only vaguely like us—like Road Runner (if not Wile E. Coyote) in the cartoons. Other times, we identify with protagonists who are very much like us, as in stories about friends, relatives, or neighbors. Sometimes the protagonists of a story are *us*, as when we find ourselves in the midst of an unfolding story, in which we are the authors of the outcome.

Why do we care?

Is it because someday I may face the same challenge and I want to be prepared? If I watch closely, might I learn what to do, learn the skills I need to

be ready? Maybe I'm just curious: I want to see what happens. But why do I care how it turns out? The fact is that we spend billions of dollars a year on movies, books, plays, songs, and sports, all structured in the same way. And they pretty much all start in the same way.

The Plot

Think about it for a moment. How many times a day do we have to deal, in ways little and big, with the unexpected? They're sold out of tickets at the movie theater. There's no place to park. Marriages break up. People lose their jobs. We all lose loved ones—losses for which almost by definition we cannot be prepared. Isn't having to deal with the unexpected, with the disruptive, a core dimension of human experience? And we seem infinitely curious to learn how.

The power of a story moment depends on our ability to make the past, present, or the distant nearby. We can tell stories because our species, unlike most others, is capable of episodic memory, to recall not only semantic data, but an event, an episode.²¹ So we can bring the moment alive by telling it in the present tense, for example, by drawing on very specific sensory details: sounds, smells, textures, and especially visuals. This is what good storytellers have known for thousands of years, the dynamics of which modern science is only just catching up to.

We link story moments that tell of the challenge, the change, the outcome, and hope to tell our story of self, story of us, and story of now. And all of these elements combine to form our public narrative. The experience of these stories becomes a part of our own experience. Bruner describes this as *agency training*: a way we learn to make mindful choices in the face of uncertainty. Stories thus teach us how to engage our emotions, not to repress them, so we can act with agency to face our own challenges.

The Moral

Story moments thus teach the heart as well as the head. Stories can instruct us what to value, how to choose, how to respond. They can also inspire, enabling us to act. They are not simply examples and illustrations. When they are well told, we experience *the point*. It is that experience, not the words as such, that enable us to learn, to choose, and to act.

A story is like a poem. It moves not by how long it is, nor how eloquent or complicated. It moves by offering the experience of specific moments through which we grasp the feeling or insight the poet communicates. The more specific the details we choose to recount, the more we can move our listeners, the more powerfully we can articulate our values, what moral philosopher Charles Taylor calls our “moral sources.”²² Like a poem, the particularity of a story moment can open a portal to the experience of the transcendent. Stories teach a moral—an experiential moral. We’ve all heard the ending—“and that is the moral of the story.” Have you ever been at a party where someone starts telling a story and they go on . . . and on . . . and on . . . and on? Someone may finally shout, “Get to the point!” We deploy stories to *make a point*, to elicit a response.

The moral of a successful story is an emotional experience, not only a cognitive takeaway. It is a lesson for the heart, not only for the head. Saying haste makes waste does not communicate how haste making waste feels, what it’s like to lose it all because I moved too fast. Nor does a moral provide detailed tactical information. We do not retell the story of David and Goliath to learn how to use a slingshot. We learn that the little guy—with courage, resourcefulness, and imagination—can beat the big guy, especially one with Goliath’s arrogance. We can feel David’s outrage, courage, and resourcefulness. We can be hopeful in dealing with apparently overwhelming challenges of our own. Stories thus teach us how to engage our emotions, not to repress them, so we can act with agency to face our own challenges.

This is why we tell stories—to instruct, to share values, and to inspire. This is why our faith traditions teach through stories, our cultural traditions teach through stories, and our families teach through stories. Where did you hear your first stories? From a parent, a grandparent, an aunt, an uncle?

Let me tell you about Uncle Charlie. He had everything going for him: good at sports, good school, good job. But then he took a wrong turn . . . and it was all downhill. You don’t want to be like Uncle Charlie, do you? So let me tell you about Aunt Harriet. Now she got it right. . . .

Families across the world tell versions of this story. Bruner reported that 85 percent of parents’ time with young children is spent in storytelling.²³ You may have children of your own. So why all the stories? To keep them busy, no doubt. But isn’t it also to instruct? Why not just read a list of rules? Do this and don’t do that? It doesn’t work, does it? It’s all in the head. Stories

teach what it feels like to deal with adversity, temptation, and arrogance, what it feels like to choose well—or poorly—in response, and where to go to get the courage to choose well—the values. The experience of these stories then becomes a part of the child's own experience—a moral resource. Bruner describes this as *agency training*: a way we learn to make mindful choices in the face of uncertainty.

Authoring Your Public Narrative

Recall our definition of leadership: accepting responsibility for enabling others to achieve shared purpose under conditions of uncertainty. As a leader, I'm not trying to compel people to choose what I want; rather, I'm enabling them to choose what they want. Leadership enables the exercise of individual and collective agency, the ability to choose well. The telling of public narrative works in three ways: a story of self, a story of us, and a story of now (Figure 3.3). This framework was inspired by Rabbi Hillel's three questions, on which our whole approach to leadership is based. I tell a story of *self* to evoke experience of values that called me to accept leadership. I tell a story of *us* to evoke shared values that can enable agency in choosing a response. I tell a story of *now* to evoke experience of the urgent challenge to those values that demands a response now, the sources of hope to enable the agency to choose well, and clarity as to the choices we must make to respond. Public narrative can also be understood in terms of Aristotle's definition of the three components of rhetoric. The *logos* is the logic of the argument. The *pathos* is the emotional content. The *ethos* is the listeners' experience of the storyteller, the credibility of the person who makes the argument—their story of self.

Stories of Self

If I am not for myself, who will be for me? You tell a story of self to share values that have called you to leadership—not as abstract principles but as lived experience. You construct your story of self from moments to which you had to respond, when you faced a challenge, made a choice, experienced an outcome, and learned a moral. You can communicate your motivating values by selecting particular story moments and recounting what happened as if it were happening now. Because storytelling is a social interaction, you engage

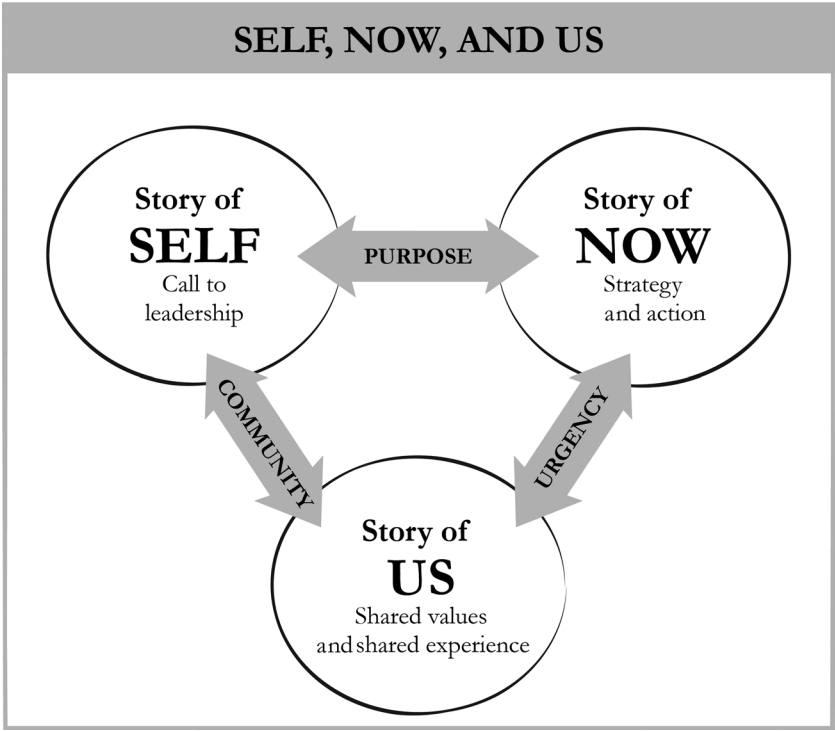


Figure 3.3 Self, Now, and Us. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

your listeners’ memories as well as your own. The experience occurs at the intersection of the moments you share and the moments your listeners recall. In fact, we construct our identities by telling our story. What is utterly unique about each of us is not a combination of the categories—race, gender, class, profession, marital status—that include us, but rather the meaning we give to our own journey, our way through life, our personal text from which each of us can teach.

We may think our personal stories don’t matter, that others won’t care, or that we shouldn’t talk about ourselves so much. On the contrary, if we do public work, we have a responsibility to give a public account of ourselves—where we came from, why we do what we do, and where we think we’re going. This is one way we can acquire the moral authority to be heard by others. The truth is that if we choose public leadership, we don’t have a choice about telling our story of self. If we don’t author our story, others will—and they may tell our story in ways that we may not like. This was the hard lesson

learned by John Kerry, the 2004 Democratic presidential nominee. When Kerry was unable to tell his own story, his opponents seized ownership of it. Something similar happened to Hillary Clinton in 2016. This outcome is not necessarily a product of malevolence: others try to make sense of who we are by relying on their experience of people they consider to be like us.

Stories of self can be challenging because people are often moved to participate in social change through a prophetic combination of criticality and hope. In personal terms, this means that most people called to social movements have lived stories of the world's hurt and the world's hope. If we hadn't felt the hurt, we wouldn't think the world needs fixing. If we hadn't felt the hope, we wouldn't think we could. And if we haven't talked about our stories of pain very much, it can take a while to learn to manage it. But if others try to make sense of why we are doing what we are doing, but we have left this piece out, our account will lack authenticity, raising questions about the rest of the story.

Social movements are often the crucibles within which participants learn to tell new stories of self as we interact with other participants. In the early days of the women's movement, people participated in consciousness-raising sessions: group conversations that mediated changes in their stories of self, in their stories of who they were, as women. Women shared stories of pain, but also stories of hope. In the civil rights movement, African Americans living in the Deep South who feared claiming the right to vote had to encourage one another to find the courage to make that claim, which, once made, began to alter how they thought of themselves and how they could interact with their children, with white people, and with each other.

Stories of Us

When I am for myself alone, what am I? We tell stories of us more often than any other kind of story. At a family dinner, for example, stories of us begin with "remember the time that . . ." or "remember when. . ." The storyteller then recounts a familiar story moment through which they experience values they share—courage, resilience, or foolishness.²⁴ Or after an athletic event, fans may gather over beers to recall when so-and-so threw the winning pass or when so-and-so fumbled the ball. In this way we celebrate the values that make "us" an "us": courage, coming through in the crunch, persistence, and so on.

When it comes to leadership, our intent is to enable our “us” to respond with hope rather than to react with fear: to exercise the agency to choose our actions well. The “us” we are constructing is experiential, not categorical. We build a categorical “us” defined by ascriptive characteristics a group may share, such as everyone with brown hair. We build an experiential “us” defined by values we share. We can experience shared values by recalling specific story moments in which we felt them: when we all stood up at the meeting to volunteer; when we all rushed onto the field when our team won the crucial game; when we all first met and were uncertain about our relationship to one another, but when someone’s baby began to cry, we all rushed over to offer support. That’s when we knew who we are.

Some story moments may be shared by an entire generation, such as the moment we heard JFK had been shot or the moment we saw the planes crash into the Twin Towers. Our cultures are repositories of story moments: stories of the challenges we have faced, how we stood up to them, and how we survived are woven into the fabric of our political cultures and our faith traditions. We tell and retell these stories as folk sayings, songs, religious practice, and celebrations (Easter, Holi, Passover, Fourth of July, Eid). And like individual stories, stories of us can inspire, teach, offer hope, or advise caution. We often adapt old stories to new challenges. The Puritans retold the Exodus story as a source of courage and justification when they colonized North America; African Americans told it again when they fought for their civil rights in the freedom movement.

We can bound an “us” very broadly, extending membership to people with few shared values and experiences, as when a president begins a speech with “my fellow Americans.” Alternatively, we can narrow the “us” to those with specific shared values and experiences, as at a family meeting or among workmates or day care partners. Broad bounding can be inclusive, narrow bounding, exclusive. The appropriateness of either depends on the purpose for which the “us” is created, the values they share, and the agency those values enable. A story of us may articulate values that transcend one’s community, but it must be included, shared by the community. A story of us can also be told to distinguish our community from another, reducing uncertainty about what to expect from those with whom we interact. Social scientists often describe a story of us as a collective identity.²⁵

For a collection of people to become an “us” requires an interpreter of shared experience, a storyteller. In a social movement, the interpretation of the movement’s new experience is a critical leadership function. And like the

story of self, the story of us is built from the founding, the choices made, the challenges faced, the outcomes experienced, the lessons learned.

Stories of us also bring attention to the sources of hope, and often power, that those in the group share. Classic eve-of-battle speeches by generals, such as in Shakespeare's *Henry V*, and halftime speeches by coaches, such as Al Pacino's in *Any Given Sunday*, don't promise victory, and most don't even mention the opposition. Rather they focus on enabling people to experience the creation of real value that is within their hands, win or lose. Shakespeare's King Henry V, for example, stirs hope in his men's hearts by offering them a different view of themselves. No longer are they a few bedraggled soldiers led by a young and inexperienced king in an obscure corner of France, about to be wiped out by an overwhelming force. Now they are a "happy few," united with their king in solidarity, holding an opportunity to grasp immortality in their hands, to become legends in their own time, a legacy for their children and grandchildren.²⁶ This is their time!

Stories of Now

If not now, when? On August 23, 1963, when Dr. King delivered the speech known as "I Have a Dream" to some 250,000 at the Capitol Mall, and to the nation, he described the purpose to be,

to remind America of the fierce urgency of Now. This is no time to engage in the luxury of cooling off or to take the tranquilizing drug of gradualism. Now is the time to make real the promises of democracy. Now is the time to rise from the dark and desolate valley of segregation to the sunlit path of racial justice. Now is the time to lift our nation from the quicksand of racial injustice to the solid rock of brotherhood. Now is the time to make justice a reality for all of God's children.

When we recall this as the "I Have a Dream" speech, we misremember the prophetic voice in which it was given with its proper title: "The Fierce Urgency of Now." Prophets don't make people comfortable. They make people uncomfortable. Before bringing alive the dream, Dr. King brought alive the nightmare. He confronted us with the nightmare of "whites only" signs across the South for water fountains, lunch counters, hotels, and poll booths. That summer, Mississippi NAACP president Medgar Evers had been assassinated.

Four little girls had been murdered when their Birmingham church was dynamited. And in the same city, police dogs and fire hoses had been turned on children marching to demand their rights. The favored chant of the movement had changed from “Freedom” sometime to “Freedom Now!”

This is the experience a story of now is intended to create. And unlike stories of self and stories of us that bring experiences of moments in the past into the present, a story of now is in the present: it is a challenge we face, a choice we can make, and an outcome that may result. In fact, a story of now is when story and strategy come together—when the *why* we need to do what we need to do (story) joins the *how* we could do what we need to do (strategy). I discuss strategy more fully in the next chapter, but a key element in hope is a plausible vision of how we could get from here to there.

We spell out the urgent challenge or threat to values we hold, that we share. It may be urgent because of need, or it may be urgent because of opportunity. We ask people to make a choice—an ask that also must be specific, not any one of fifty-three things that you would be comfortable doing. The reality is that people will commit their most precious resource—their time—not because it’s easy but because it’s valuable, because they can do something that could make a real difference to the desired outcome. A choice is something like, “Can we commit to boycotting every single bus in Montgomery, Alabama, until we win? Yes or no?”

The story of now is that moment in which story (why) and strategy (how) overlap and in which, as poet Seamus Heaney writes, “Justice can rise up, and hope and history rhyme.”²⁷ For the claim to be credible, the action must begin right here, right now, in this room, with action each one of us can take. It’s the story of a credible strategy, with an account of how starting with who and where we are, and how we can, step-by-step, get to where we want to go. Our action can call forth the actions of others, and their actions can call others, and together these actions can carry the day.

Linking Self, Us, and Now

Public narrative only becomes a leadership practice when we link all three stories together into a coherent, cohesive, and compelling values-based narrative. A linked narrative communicates why you care (story of self), why we care (story of us), and why we are called to respond to threats to those values (story of now). The goal is to create an experience of your values (story of self)

and the values of the people you hope will join you in collective action (story of us) with the values being threatened by the urgent challenge(s) you're facing that require hopeful action (story of now).

All three stories are interdependent in practice, much like a three-legged stool, because each story part must be strong for the linked story to stand. Imagine that you have strong stories of self and now but a weak story of us: your listeners may understand what you care about and what you hope to do about it, but if they don't feel connected to the story and to each other, why would they join you? If you have strong stories of us and now with a weak story of self, the group may feel connected to each other and compelled to take collective action, but what reason do they have to trust and join *you*? As a leader, you've failed to offer a sense of who you are and why you care, or to establish any kind of moral authority. Finally, if you have strong stories of self and us but a weak story of now, then you've succeeded in bringing a group together—one that feels connected and hopeful about itself! But then what? If you're not drawing people together for a *shared purpose*—to act and face a challenge of some kind—then it may be a fun time, but it's not *leadership*.

In a linked narrative, the story of self, story of us, and story of now are woven together by values. This narrative communicates the speaker's values through the story of self, lifts up the values that connect members of the "us" with each other, and that are challenged by the story of now. This is called "values coherence": when the same or similar values are experienced in all three stories.

When people first try to link their narrative together, it's not uncommon for one or more of the stories to deteriorate, to be given very little time, or to drop out completely. This can be for several reasons (e.g., time, lack of understanding of the craft, wanting to share less vulnerability). But the story of self is foundational to a linked narrative: it's where the values running through the story are rooted. If a narrative has a strong self, it can potentially ground a weaker us and now; however, a weak self affects the strength of a narrative and can make it ineffective. It's in the story of self that a leader establishes their moral authority, helping people understand who they are and why they care. While every story of self may not be an origin story, we find that origin stories are the most powerful in enabling people to connect with the speaker; when we know how, where, and when they learned to care about their values, that foundation connects the rest of the narrative too. It is also sometimes easier for people to articulate their sources of hurt than their sources of hope, yet it's from the story of hope that they have so much to teach us.

As we noted earlier, public narrative is a *framework* not a formula, so the order of the stories (self, us, now) can be varied and played with, just as long as they make sense and flow together in a clear, cohesive way. Nor is public narrative a way of asking people to do you a favor or manipulating people to do what you want; rather, it's about communicating what's important to you, calling on people who share those values, and offering them a *choice* and an *opportunity* to act on those values to take hopeful and meaningful action in the face of an urgent challenge. An effective linked narrative should answer the following questions for the audience (the "us") whom the speaker is trying to call to action:

Story of Self: Do we get what this person is all about? Do we know what they value and care about and why? When did they learn to care?

Story of Us: Do we get what we're about? Do people in this room share that same value? How do we know that? Did the story make us feel more connected to each other? What moments did they share about the group that show we care?

Story of Now: Do we know what challenge they're asking us to act on? Is it clear what they want us to do and what impact it will have? Do we feel compelled to act because something we hold dear is threatened? Do we know what happens if we don't act (*the nightmare*)? What could the future look like if we do act (*the dream*)? Is there a sense of urgency? Must we act now?

The Challenge of Narrative Leadership

The Empathetic Bridge

Although every "now" moment could be an opportunity to practice leadership by enabling others—their "us"—to respond to the disruption with agency as opposed to reacting with fear, we can use an "empathetic bridge" to focus specifically on the interaction between "self" and "us." We pay particular attention to the actual words used to communicate in such moments, planned or not—words do matter. We do this by focusing on four particularly challenging and, at the same time, most widely experienced moments: loss, difference, domination, and change. This approach is grounded in a respectful engagement. We know how it feels to be respected: it is to be seen,

to be heard, and to be valued—not to be pitied or rescued. We use the empathetic bridge with respect, drawing on our own resources to enable others to draw on theirs.

The empathetic bridge has four elements (Figure 3.4):

- **Acknowledge the challenge.** Do not ignore it, deny its importance, or tell the other person not to feel bad. These words dismiss or belittle real pain, fear, or anger. Respect requires recognizing the hurt of others.
- **Offer empathy, but do not claim it.** Do not say, “I know just how you feel,” because you don’t. Speak rather from your own experience. People often respond to a friend’s news that a loved one got diagnosed with cancer by sharing a story from their own experience. Making yourself

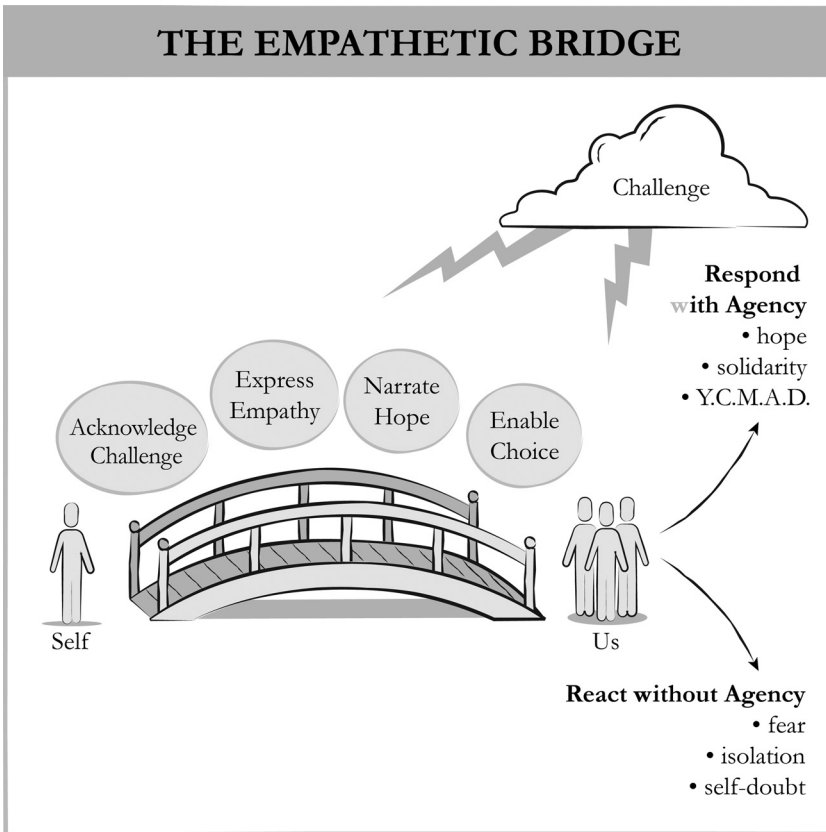


Figure 3.4 The Empathetic Bridge. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

empathetically available can create a brave space within which others can experience validation for their own feelings.

- **Narrate hope.** Don't promise everything will be okay. It may not be. And you can't promise it anyway. Don't promise that something or someone will miraculously save the day. In our own lives and the life of our community, we have sources of hope that have enabled us to get this far: in our faith, our relationships, our improbable life experiences. As Maimonides suggested, hope lives in the space between certainty and fantasy: the possible if not the probable.²⁸ We can elicit sources of hope from within our own life experiences and those of others.
- **Offer a choice.** When we experience a deeply disruptive blow, we can lose our sense of agency or our ability to choose our future. The last step in the empathetic bridge is to restore choice. It is not by telling others what they should do, must do, or will do. Instead, it is in offering possible choices to your "us" that they can make now. It may be a choice of how to respond emotionally to what has happened. Do we let it overwhelm us so much that we must hide, or do we discover that we can find the sources of courage and solidarity to face it?

Although these elements are evident in Robert F. Kennedy's speech delivering the news of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s assassination to a Black audience in Indianapolis, Indiana, on April 4, 1968, a more recent example is the address by Jacinda Ardern, the prime minister of New Zealand, to the nation on March 29, 2019, following the murder of fifty Muslim men, women, and children in Christ Church on March 15.

In this way we can draw on the empathetic bridge to equip leaders to enable their "us" to respond to these four challenges. Each of the conceptual frameworks we use, however, is only a lens through which we may choose to look at a complex reality to the extent it proves useful. A single moment of disruption can be looked at through multiple lenses, each suggesting different ways to respond. Change, for example, often involves loss; difference often involves power. Using different lenses to understand a moment of disruption can illuminate perspectives, nuances, and connections that you may not have noticed before and that can turn out to have critical bearing on the problem you're trying to solve.

Leadership Challenges: How to Restore Agency

Loss

We begin with the challenge of loss. Narrative psychologist Dan McAdams identifies two ways people may interpret the experience of loss. One is *contaminative*: the experience of loss is so hurtful that it becomes predictive—good things will always go bad, I will always be a victim, etc. McAdams calls the other way to respond *redemptive*: the loss is real, painful, and lonely, but it can also become a source of learning, growth, discovery, and resilience.²⁹

Difference

We then turn to the challenge of difference: how widely or narrowly to bound the *us* with whom we engage. The leadership challenge is to approach bounding strategically based on the core values that members share and the agency to be enabled. Narrow bounding is rooted more in multiple kinds of shared experiences, as with members of a particular team. Broad bounding is rooted in fewer kinds of shared experience but may be more inclusive, as with an entire school. Neither is good or bad. The objective is to evoke values shared by the “us” to enable it to act with agency. We may also consider the depth of the shared experience in which our “us” is rooted. We may experience moments of parenting, for example, quite deeply no matter how widely shared. We may also experience neighborliness quite lightly, even though many of these experiences are shared.

Domination

The challenge of domination occurs in any moment in which a dominant and a subordinate meet. Drawing on the work of political scientist James Scott,³⁰ we can distinguish among four different stories being told in such a moment: the public and hidden stories of the subordinate and the public and hidden stories of the dominant. The question is how to use narrative to enable the agency of the subordinate and, at times, even the dominant on a continuum from compliance to resistance. When and how do we choose to comply or resist?

Choosing is a matter of responding with agency rather than reacting. Power depends on strategy—can we turn the resources we have into the power we need to win? Similar choices can be made on the dominant side as well.

Change

Finally, with the challenge of unexpected change, we ask how leaders can enable their “us” to respond mindfully to this disruptive change. This does not refer to the change we seek but rather to change that is thrust upon us. We consider four positions: (1) deny the reality of change by insisting on the old story, (2) deny the reality of the old story, insisting on an entirely new story, (3) accept elements of change to the extent they can be accommodated within the old story, or (4) accept elements of the old story to the extent they can be adapted to a new story.

These four leadership challenges describe the kinds of disruptions many of us have experienced in our own lives. Here we look at them as leadership challenges: how can we enable others—and not just ourselves—to respond with agency?

Practicing Public Narrative

As we learn to practice public narrative, we can also turn moments that have been influences on us—some of which we may have forgotten—into resources for us. When asked why we do what we do, we often respond, “I always wanted to be a teacher.” Always? But unless you came out of the womb with a book in your hands, you discovered your calling primarily through experiences like those we have discussed in this chapter.

When it comes to stories of self, origin stories really matter. Our own stories, like any story, begin in the beginning. We begin forming our values early in life through the challenges we face growing up, engaging with others, dealing with stress, and experiencing our own value—or not. These experiences often occur with siblings, parents, grandparents, aunts and uncles, teachers, and classmates. When we are recognized, experience being loved, or otherwise experience success, these encounters may be very affirming, or they may be negative. We may have been excluded, required to shoulder responsibility beyond our years, or experienced abuse in many forms. Although our experience of our formative years may have been quite hurtful, it is unlikely our origin story would stop there. Most of us have had moments of hurt or we wouldn’t believe the world needs fixing. But if we hadn’t had moments of hope, we wouldn’t be trying to fix it.

A mom comforts us, a teacher sees us, a sibling supports us, the natural world heals us, our faith uplifts us, or we find sources of resilience that

surprise us. It is often in these experiences of hurt and hope, of wounds and scars, that we learn to find value and create value with others. While life may not unfold in a straight line, these moments are nevertheless where we begin. Astronauts, surgeons, carpenters, and organizers all have origin stories. These stories are the kind of experience that can find the deepest resonance with the experience of others, and we may discover values we share despite sharply different occupations, nationalities, political preferences, or faith traditions. This can be a very empowering discovery.

Telling about a story is different from telling a story. When we tell a story, we bring the past into the present or the distant into the proximate. We enable the listener to enter its time and place with us, see what we see, hear what we hear, feel what we feel. An actor friend once told me the key was to speak entirely in the present tense and avoid using the word “and.” I step into the room. It is dark. I hear a sound.

You cannot learn to practice public narrative looking into the mirror. We need coaching. A Yiddish riddle asks, “Who discovered water?” The answer is, “I don’t know, but it wasn’t a fish.” We are all fish in the water of our own stories, so we need a coach or an interlocutor to ask us the probing questions that can enable us to recall specific moments in which we learned to care and learned to hope, moments we may even have forgotten about. This can be uncomfortable, even scary, but the reality is that learning is often uncomfortable because we are setting out beyond our comfort zones. Pedagogical scholar Lev Vygotsky’s insight into the role of discomfort in the social nature of learning describes what he calls the “zone of proximal development.”³¹ For a child to move beyond their comfort zone, the affirmation and challenge that can be offered by another person is critical for the child’s development—often the role of a parent. And it isn’t only children who hesitate to take a step beyond their comfort zone.

A coach can motivate us to step out of the comfort zone into a zone of proximal development and by offering us challenge and support. A coach may connect the dots we haven’t connected because we are so within our own story that we have not learned to articulate them.

As I shared in my introduction, you can’t learn to practice public narrative, or any other practice, simply by reading about it. Like learning to ride a bike, it requires getting on, falling off, learning, and getting back on again. You’ve been reading lots of explanations about how it works, so now it’s time to observe a model, debrief it, and then you may be ready to go practice with a partner yourself.

James Croft crafted this five-minute public narrative when he was a student. His story calls us to respond to the crisis of suicide among gay youth.³² As you read James's story, or watch it, ask yourself these questions: When is he telling a story of self, a story of us, and a story of now? Why does he choose the moments that he chooses? Why all the details? What are the values this story evokes?

James Croft: Modeling Public Narrative

6.12 seconds. That's about how long it takes to fall 604 feet. And 604 feet is about how far Tyler Clemente fell after he jumped off the George Washington Bridge. Now as we know, he took his own life because live video footage of him having a romantic encounter with another man was streamed live on the Internet by his college roommate. Just one on a very long list of young people who have taken their lives because of anti-LGBT bullying in the past few weeks.

Now I never experienced anything like what Tyler went through when I was at school, but I was bullied for being gay. You see, when I was a kid, I was a ballet dancer, and every week I squeezed into a leotard and blue shiny hot pants. It was, uh, quite an outfit, and I spent an evening practicing demi-pliés and pirouettes, and I loved it. I loved the discipline, the music played on the old piano, the feel of the wood beneath my feet. I even secretly quite liked the outfit.

But my schoolmates and some of my teachers didn't like ballet as much as I did, and one of my teachers, a PE teacher, used to make fun of me. He used to say how girly I was, how dancing is not something that boys should do. I remember the sneer on his face as I walked past, and I remember that he was the first person to call me a fag, which at seven years old, I didn't really understand. I remember in high school how "gay" was only ever used as a term of abuse, and I remember one cold morning sitting in assembly while the principal intoned, "Homosexuals deserve our pity and our prayers." And I sat among hundreds of other boys thinking that I was alone in the world, and that I was the only one who had this . . . problem.

Now not everyone may have experienced something like that, but we all know, I think, what it means to feel alone—to feel like there's no one on our side. Perhaps you were too tall, and the short kids made fun of you. Or perhaps you were too short, and you got it from the taller ones. Or perhaps you were too smart, or too dumb, or from the wrong side of town, or the wrong race. We all know, I think, even if just for a moment, what it feels like to think that there's no one on your side. To think that no one has your back . . .

And all of us, if there are young people in our lives that we care about, can agree that we don't want this to happen to them. Imagine, if you can, what it must be like to come home and see a strange shape hanging from a tree in your backyard, twisting in the wind, the creak of the branch that bends beneath the weight, and that feeling in your gut as you get closer and you realize what it is hanging there, who it is—who it was. Because that was Seth Walsh, 13, who hung himself from a tree in his backyard. It was Billy Lucas who hung himself at his grandmother's house, and it was Raymond Chase who hung himself in his dorm, and it could have been your brother, your sister, your son, your daughter, or your friend. It could have been one of us . . .

So, I know—I—I only came out in March this year, after ten years, ten years after I first told my parents I thought I was gay. And in those ten years I lost a lot of opportunities to make a difference. I was a high school teacher, and every day I wasn't out was a day I deprived a gay student of a positive role model. And I'm not willing to waste any more time. I have to act now. We have to act now. Because it isn't enough to let these things happen and then mourn them afterwards. We need to capture these kids before they jump.

And there is something we can do to help, as a start. Journalist Dan Savage just started a campaign, the It Gets Better Campaign, to send messages of hope to teenagers who are being bullied because they're gay, or for whatever reason, that they should have hope for their future, that they do have something to live for. And I think that if we made such a video, as Harvard students with glittering careers ahead of us and sparkling degrees, that we could make a difference.

So, we need people to hold a camera, to share their stories, to do editing and sound, to stand in a big group, and say it gets better. No contribution is too small. And if you want to get involved, and you're an undergraduate, talk to Tevin, and he'll tell you how to get involved. If you're a graduate student, or if you just wanna come along, from 5 to 7 p.m. in the Elliott Lyman room in Longfellow Hall at the Education School's campus . . .

Stand up and say, we're standing with these kids. We've got your back. Let's catch them before they jump.

Debriefing James Croft

When is he telling a story of self, a story of us, a story of now? He begins with a story-of-now moment: "6.12 seconds. That's about how long it takes to fall 604 feet. And 604 feet is about how far Tyler Clemente fell after he jumped off the George Washington Bridge."

Why is this a story of now? He confronts us with an urgent challenge: the 6.12 seconds it took for this young man to fall from the bridge. We react to this image in ways that make the challenge feel real, urgent, and compelling. We are shown, rather than told about the reality of suicide among gay youth. Stories move by replacing adjectives with images. We begin to get it.

Where does he go next? The ballet. As vivid as it is, why does he begin his story of self with that moment? He is determined not to become an iconic victim, so he starts by taking us to a moment of joy, a joy we feel. It's as if he were saying, "Look, I'm a real human being, capable of joy, delight in colors, sounds, love for what I do, for who I am."

Then, in sharp contrast, he takes us to the moment when he was seven and his gym teacher hurls the insult at him. We flinch. We experience the insult. See the impact. And we react most likely with a flash of anger—or, at the very least, concern. We begin to get why he is doing what he's doing.

We then see him in the moment when he is sitting in the auditorium among hundreds. Yet he is all alone in his reaction to specifically demeaning words of the principal. What if all we had heard was "the principal spoke derogatorily of gay people"? He's showing us, not telling us.

Then he makes a shift. He begins to shift to a story of us. We may not have had the identical experience, but he asks, have we never felt alone, isolated,

fearful, without support? In this way he calls to mind those moments of our own, how they felt, how much someone on your side matters. We begin to become a broadly yet deeply bounded “us,” connected with each other.

Now that Croft has us, he takes us to another more intense now moment, a moment we experience together: a body hangs from a tree, the branch creaks, the wind blows. We feel dread, heartsick, sorrow as we realize “what it was . . . who it was.” These are not data points. They are human beings with names—Seth Walsh, Billy Lucas, Raymond Chase. They could have been our brother, or sister, they could have been one of us.

And isn’t that image of bodies hanging from trees a familiar one, at least in the United States? Between 1882 and 1968, 3,446 African Americans were lynched in the United States, an image we are shown in Billie Holiday’s singing of “Strange Fruit” with “blood at the leaf and blood at the root.”³³

Croft doesn’t have to say a word about injustice. He confronts us with the image of injustice. He shows. He doesn’t have to tell.

Croft then returns to his story of self. He has more work to do. We haven’t heard much about hope so far. He begins by referring to the moment he came out only a few months before. Although he had told his parents he was gay ten years before, he had not publicly come out during his time as a high school teacher, thus depriving gay kids of a role model. In part, his failure to act then is why he needs to act now, and that is exactly what he is doing.

But wait a moment. As a leader he’s calling us to act now, something he didn’t do for ten years. Why confess his failure, his vulnerability? Won’t we lose confidence in him as a leader? To the contrary, despite his failure to act then, he has found the courage to act now. Because he failed before, we can find hope in the fact he found the courage to act now. Because he found the courage, so can we. By owning his vulnerability, we can learn from his courage—a critical dynamic when it comes to leadership.

What can we learn from a perfect person? To be perfect? Where do I start? This is one reason I’ve learned so much from the story of Moses. He is so flawed, yet his struggles to overcome those flaws teach us so much.

We have experienced the challenge, we have experienced the hope, so what is the ask?

Croft gets us there through a story of now: “We must catch these kids before they jump!” He offers us a path to action we can take, should we choose to. We can join the It Gets Better campaign by making videos of hope and solidarity for gay youth feeling isolated and hopeless. It is specific, something we can do, and suited for his “us” with their “sparkling degrees.” There

is nothing generic in his ask—he's not saying that someone can make a difference, but that you can make a difference. And his ask is part of a larger campaign, encouraging people to join an effort they believe really could make a difference.

Croft accepts the strategic responsibility that comes with leadership to offer us a specific way forward. We know where to meet, when to meet, with whom to meet, and how we can contribute. We can catch these kids before they jump.

What are the values that link the parts of this public narrative into a coherent whole—values that link Croft's story of self, story of us, and story of now? Remember, values are experiential. We experience values of respect, solidarity, inclusion, compassion, and responsibility. We experience moments in which these values were challenged or threatened, or when their opposites were present (e.g., isolation, exclusion, scorn, cowardice), and these moments contrast with moments of hope, when these values were present, powerful, and motivating.

Finally, by looking at Croft's public narrative, we can see how it's a framework, not a formula. Unlike Obama's 2004 talk, the first seven minutes are not a linear self, us, and now. Instead, Croft moves back and forth between them. He begins with a story of now (6.12 seconds, Tyler Clemente jumping off the bridge, the reality of gay teens committing suicide), moves to a story of self that shares his own experiences (ballet dancer, gym teacher, moment in the auditorium). He then goes to a story of us (asking the audience to recall their experience of bullying, isolation, and exclusion), then goes back to the story of now (finding bodies hanging from trees), touches on the us (imagine if it were your son, daughter, friend, etc.), then briefly returns to the self (his late coming-out and depriving students of a role model) before moving into his call to action (story of now), asking people to join with him to become a part of the It Gets Better campaign.

Conclusion

My first teaching foray outside the English-speaking world was in Amman, Jordan, in an organizing workshop with some fifty NGO leaders in collaboration with my colleague Nisreen Haj Ahmad. I was warned that, in this world, people would never tell a story of self. This was despite the rich Arab tradition of *hakawatis* or storytellers famous for leaving listeners hanging so they

would return the next night to the coffeehouse to learn what happened next. Especially, I was told, men would not do this.

Indeed, one of the men insisted firmly that he had no story to tell about why he had become an environmental activist, despite work by our best coach, community leader Samar Dudin. But the next morning, this man arrived with the news that he had indeed found his story. He shared with the whole workshop:

I grew up in a village where my father had olive trees. He loved his trees. They were his pride and joy. The Qur'an tells us that even in combat one is to spare the innocent and the trees. Trees are sources of life. Then, one day, the bulldozers came, tore out all the trees, and my father fell on the ground on his back, tears in his eyes. And that's when I knew I had to save the trees.

He received a standing ovation.

I was back in Amman about a year ago, where Nisreen and her colleagues have been doing great work for the last ten years. I was to give a talk about organizing to what turned out to be a paying audience of some four hundred. In my talk I told this story, and a hand went up. "That's me. That's my story! Just as it is!"

Leadership is a relational practice. And as Rabbi Hillel observed, we must make ourselves—our full selves—accessible to others for anyone to enter a relationship with us. Our story of self gives our identity coherence—a past, a present, a possible future—as we evolve our self dynamically over the course of our lives. But we do not constitute ourselves by ourselves. Instead, we articulate ourselves in relationship to others, how they see us, how they interact with us and us with them. Leadership requires enabling others to work together. So we tell a story of us. Leadership also requires action—not in the distant future—but in the present. So we tell a story of now.

We turn now to strategy, story's partner, to learn how we can enable others to respond to challenge by turning what we have into what we need to get what we want.